

" Shapes of Educational Gender Discrimination in Iran"

Abstract

Since the revolution of 1978 to 1979, the situation of women in Iran has been complicated and contradictory, and when viewed from abroad, it is frequently oversimplified. The late 19th and early 20th centuries saw the birth of some trailblazing women and men who battled for more equitable rights for women in Iran and other Middle Eastern countries. Many of their early battles were for schools because, up until that point, fewer girls than boys had received formal education outside of the home. Many clerics and their adherents at first opposed girls attending cleric-only schools, but finally a great change has been made to the situation of education between girls. However, these attempts could not solve all the aspects of gender discrimination in education and consequently the problem of education among young girls, and women. To solve such problems completely, analyzing all the aspects carefully is a necessity. This gets even more important while some organizations like Nayak*, which have been built and promoted outside the borders of Iran, do their best to hide realities and make a better face of what is really happening (سالاری, 2022). The focus of this paper is on the various shapes of gender discrimination and the various ways it is taught to students of all genders and sexual orientations.

Keywords: Gender discrimination in Iran, Iran's education system, Bias in Education in Iran, Iranian Girls, Feminism in Iran

*Nayak: Nayak is an association built outside the borders of Iran, it considers its first goal to be "building political relations between Iran and America". Opponents of Nayak's activities say that this means trying to establish a political relationship between America and the Islamic Republic as the official custodian of Iran's politics because Iranian people have no enmity with America. Many Iranians accuse Nayak of lobbying for the Islamic Republic and also hiding the reality and human rights violations happening in Iran, and for this reason, this organization is infamous among them.

Chances of Education

Paying attention to educational levels without sexual discrimination is one of the most crucial challenges in every nation. Every society's fundamental component that increases knowledge, investment, health indicators, and safety is education. The Iranian Ministry of Science, Education, and Technology, the World Bank, and UNESCO conducted a descriptive study using a systematic review and library study, and the results show that the most significant advancements have been made at the primary and secondary education levels, where the gender parity index in the gross enrolment ratio increased from 0.90 in 1990-1991 to 0.96 in 1999-2000. (Rezaee et al. (2012)) A notable improvement in female literacy over the past ten years can be seen in the adult literacy rates in Iran (age 15 and over), which rose from 63.2 percent in 1990 (72.2 males and 54 females) to 76 percent in 2000 (83 males and 68.9 females). The youth literacy rates (ages 15 to 24) increased from 86.3 percent (91.7 percent for men and 80.8 percent for women) to 93.8 percent (96.2 percent for men and 91.3 percent for women) between 1990 and 2000 (5).v while the progress seems promising, it still shows the social, cultural and governmental forces have stopped a balance in the rate of literacy. This is clear that such positive changes are really promising but the policies taken to encourage people to have higher education is not equal. For instance, there are 19 thousand 106 students studying in the first public intelligence high school for boys and 34 thousand 926 students in the second high public intelligence school for boys. Also, 17 thousand 188 female students are studying in the first secondary level and 33 thousand 928 female students are studying in the second secondary level at the public intelligence schools. While these schools have very difficult test for the students to enter, it seems unfair to give more seats to boys than girl. This can be seen in the bigger scale at the universities specially the ones that are free fees and have very difficult entrance exams. For instance, a new regulation was passed in order to prevent the trend of increasing the number of girls at universities and to create a balance between female and male students, the government of Iran has considered gender quotas for entering public universities, based on which at least 30% of the capacity will be available to boys. There are many opponents who believe that quotas for admission of students in entrance exam based on gender are discriminatory and create restrictions, while everyone should get the results of their efforts regardless of gender and based on merit.

Freedom of Personal Choice in Academic Environments

There are generally tougher dress standards for female students than the boys. This is while, female students are separated from male students in classrooms and on campuses, which might restrict their involvement in extracurricular and academic activities (Amnesty International, 2018). In Iran, women are required to adhere to a dress code in public places including schools and universities. A focus on modesty and the avoidance of tight or revealing attire is required by the dress code, which calls for women to wear clothing that conceals their hair and bodies. Not only the clothes but only shaving the face, having nail polish, plucking eyebrows and dying hair are all banned for girls, this is while wearing uniform at male schools is mainly not mandatory.

Iranian authorities use a number of tools to ensure that female students adhere to the clothing code, including disciplinary measures, fines, and even arrests. According to (Amnesty International (2018)), female students who disobey the dress code may suffer consequences including being expelled from school or university or being denied access to key educational opportunities. Female staff employees and teachers are also subject to the dress code, and they are expected to wear modestly. The dress requirement for women in public places like schools has drawn debate and criticism both domestically and abroad. Some claim that it violates the rights of women and limits their ability to express themselves and choose what to wear. Others contend that the dress code is essential to preserve traditional beliefs, safeguard women's modesty, and ensure their safety.

In spite of these discussions, Iran's clothing code for women in public places and schools is still in effect. The clothing code has, however, recently been modified or relaxed in several ways. For instance, Iranian authorities declared in 2018 those female students would no longer need to wear a headscarf in physical education sessions.

At universities, in which male and female can stay together, clothing gets more important. Even though, girls would be free to pluck their rows, or dye their hair but they still have to hide all their body parts and of course their hair. At most universities, there are centers and rooms with people who will check on the female students and in case of not wearing accordingly, they are even allowed to fire the student.



Sexism in the Textbooks

Human rights organizations have condemned the substantial problem of sexism in Iranian school textbooks. The literature evaluation backs up the idea that ideologies from every society are taught in textbooks. It appears that textbooks are used to convey more than simply information about a given subject; they also play a significant role in upholding the viewpoints and ideologies of the textbooks' authors (Mineshima, 2008). The way textbooks are presented to students in schools has undergone numerous modifications in Iran as a result of political, social, and cultural changes since 1979. Since the Ministry of Education has up until now controlled textbook production, it is important to take note of how elite ideologies and viewpoints are portrayed in these books. Textbooks frequently include sexist terminology and tropes, especially those that teach social studies and history.

The portrayal of women and girls in Iranian textbooks is one of the key sexism issues. Women are frequently represented as being submissive, frail, and dependent on males. Women are occasionally portrayed as merely ornamental items rather than fully developed personalities (Freedom House, 2019). Additionally, gender stereotypes and traditional gender roles are frequently reinforced in textbooks, such as the predominant portrayal of men as providers and women as caregivers. The language used to describe women in Iranian textbooks is another issue with sexism. Instead of using their names or making reference to their accomplishments, women are frequently addressed in derogatory or objectifying ways, such as by using phrases like "dear wife" or "beloved mother" (Freedom House, 2019). That women are largely defined by their relationships with men and their responsibilities as carers rather than as unique people with their own identities and accomplishments is reinforced by the language used. The Iranian government has also come under fire from Human Rights Watch for failing to address sexism in textbooks, claiming that "sexist, patriarchal attitudes and gender stereotypes continue to be pervasive." Several human rights organizations have examined the issue of sexism in Iranian textbooks. For instance, Freedom House observes that "Gender bias in textbooks remains widespread" in its 2019 report on Iran (Freedom House, 2019, p. 6). The investigation of Iranian high school English textbooks revealed that men were superior to women. In total, 1832 cases involved gender, of which 1363 involved males in the form of proper nouns, pronouns, or other representations, and 469 involved females. To put it another way, there were 74% and 26% more men than women in these three textbooks, respectively. It means that men make up nearly three times as much of the gender representation as women do. This issue seems crucial because it could affect how well female students learn. Nearly one to three men to women make up the population.



Families and Permission for Education

In Middle Eastern countries (including Iran), the breaking of the “honor code”, which was not a part of Islamic law or official Islam but was rather of tribal origin and largely observed by specific tribes and popular class people, was what girls and women had to fear most. According to this code, the sexual purity of women, especially sisters, and daughters, was where men found their greatest respect. Minor code infractions could result in (mostly unpunished) murder by patrilineal relatives in addition to adultery and fornication. This prejudice gives the family and mainly the males in the family the chance to be decision makers and the right of making decisions, this can be about important subjects like whether the girl would be able go to school or university or not. With a very common belief of “schools and universities cause the girls to be rebellious and have the awareness to demand their rights and consequently ruin family’s reputation”, many brothers and fathers stop the female member of the family from participating in higher education. This is their way of having financial, mental and physical control over women whom they seem to own.

Preventing girls and women from studying means that they no longer will be able to learn about their rights, gain financial independence and social status, this also seems to be a problem for the male members as well. The possible solution for most of these brothers, husband, grandfathers and uncles who will finally be frustrated by the costs and prices that they have to pay for not letting their female members be financially independent would be one thing, forcing them to marry another man in the hope to pass the responsibility of caring, monitoring and financially providing. Article 1041 of Iran's Civil Code sets the marriage age at 13 for girls and 15 for boys – if they have their parents' consent. But if families want to marry off a daughter who is 12 or younger – or a boy 14 or younger – they can ask a judge to declare them “intellectually mature”

enough for marriage. According to official statistics, in 5.5 percent of Iranian marriages, the brides are under 15. According to figures from 1348 (1969), 11,175 Iranian girls were married before turning 19 in Tehran, the country's capital. 3,726 of them, or around one-third of those, were under 16 and were exempt from the age restriction. The dower (Mehri'ah) paid by the groom to the bride is arguably the most significant aspect of the Iranian marriage system. The dower payment is really noted on the marriage license. For these kinds of families, it can be a comfort that the amount of dower may depend on four factors: the girl's age, virginity, physical appearance, and social class. In order to provide their daughters and possibly themselves with a better opportunity of finding employment, they forbid them from enrolling at schools or universities. Instead, they believe Mehria to be a simpler mean of financial security.



Career Opportunities after Education for Women

With women enrolling more than men in higher education, hopes of getting the job market in the female hands rises but that is not how it works. According to the rules, being a real estate consultant, a coffee shop tender, working as a judge, working in mines, getting some municipal jobs, singing, working on ships and at sea, working in the army, being a motor courier, becoming president, and being a fireman is illegal for Iranian women in Iran even if they have related studies and certifications. After completing education with the possible and allowed job opportunities, however, women still face many obstacles in pursuing careers because of discrimination and gender-based hurdles that prevent them from entering specific fields of work and receiving equal compensation. In such cases, there are no legal limitations on women working in Iran. However, gender-based discrimination against women still occurs in the workplace, and this includes lower pay, fewer opportunities for advancement, and fewer career development options.

Conclusion

Improving the standard of education that girls get in Iran is another area of hope. As part of this, it's important to address the gender-based prejudice and preconceptions that still exist in the educational system and make sure that girls have access to qualified instructors and materials. Girls can be better prepared to excel in their future academic and professional efforts by improving the quality of education in a relaxed, freer and healthier environments. Additionally, it is hoped that more women will be represented in higher education and other fields that have traditionally been dominated by men. While there have been improvements in recent years for girls in Iran in terms of higher education enrollment, there are still issues with gender-based discrimination and stereotypes that restrict their opportunities for advancement in some fields (Freedom House, 2019).

Many activists and reformers tend to reduce men's dominance and improve the status of women both inside and outside the home instead of addressing barriers to gender equality. For instance, the "natural" role of women in the home is recognized, the sexual division of labor is acceptable, and a mild form of the hijab is acceptable. The fact that Islamic feminism solely addresses the female gender further restricts it. concerns of unemployed, minority, young, and working-class women while ignoring those of middle-class, upper-class professional women. In addition, the Islamic reformists' emphasis on homogeneity pushes women who don't share their values to the margins.

The ultimate solution for such gender discriminations in education that most people agree with, would be boosting access to school, raising the standard of education, and boosting the participation of women in higher education and historically male-dominated areas are all potential improvements for girls' education in Iran. Even if there have been recent improvements, there are still major issues that must be resolved in order to give all girls an equal chance at success.

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